Council and Community Q&A

This Q&A answers common questions about automated license plate recognition (ALPR) programs and the Axon Vehicle Intelligence capabilities that support them. It explains system capabilities, governance controls and accountability in clear, practical terms.

System Overview

How is this different from another ALPR system?

The difference is in how the data is governed after capture. Axon Vehicle Intelligence is built around agency-controlled data: sharing is explicit and invite-only, no data is copied during sharing, recipient agencies cannot re-share data they receive, and all access and sharing activity is logged and reviewable by the owning agency. Each agency's data stays under its own control throughout the program's operation.

What It Is & What It Captures

What problem does this technology address?

Vehicle-related crime is a factor in many serious incidents, including stolen vehicles, hit-and-runs, missing persons cases and investigations that cross jurisdictions. In those situations, identifying a vehicle quickly can reduce the time it takes to locate a vehicle of interest and move an investigation forward. The system helps agencies confirm where a vehicle was seen and respond with better information, within defined limits on how data is collected, used and governed.

What data does the system collect?

The system captures a license plate image, a vehicle context image, basic vehicle attributes visible in the image such as color, make and vehicle type, and the time and location of the detection. The context image provides vehicle context for review. Because it is an image from the scene, it may incidentally include surroundings, signage or people in view. It is not analyzed for facial recognition or behavioral profiling. The system does not perform live registered-owner lookups or build a profile of a registered owner.

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WHAT IT IS & WHAT IT CAPTURES – CONTINUED

Is this a form of surveillance?

ALPR cameras record vehicle detections at specific camera locations. The system does not use facial recognition, perform live registered-owner lookups or maintain continuous monitoring of individuals. The agency defines who can access the data, how long it is retained and what uses are authorized. Every search is tied to a named user and logged for review.

How does the agency decide where to deploy cameras?

Camera placement is an agency decision governed by the agency's operational needs, its policies and applicable law. Agencies should be prepared to explain the reasoning behind their deployment plan if asked in a public setting.

Tracking & Movement

Does this system track people?

No. The system captures vehicle detection information, not driver identity. License plate images and vehicle context are recorded at specific camera locations. It does not use facial recognition, perform live registered-owner lookups or maintain a live location feed on any person.

Could this be used to track where people go over time?

The system does not monitor people or maintain a live location feed on anyone. When investigating a specific vehicle, an authorized user can review where and when that plate was previously captured, within the agency's retention period. That search is tied to a named user and logged with the action, time and, where configured, stated reason. It is an investigative search of a known vehicle, bounded by retention and oversight, not continuous monitoring of the public.

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Ownership, Sharing & Hotlists

Who owns and controls the data?

The agency owns and controls its ALPR data. Axon does not pool it, resell it, or disclose it except where legally required. Ownership does not change when data is preserved in Axon Evidence, and it does not change when an agency enables sharing. The agency decides retention, access and sharing. The system applies the configured controls. The agency remains responsible for policy, training and oversight.

Is this connected to a national database?

No. Data stays within the agency's environment unless the agency chooses to share it. There is no automatic cross-agency access, and the system does not place agency ALPR data into a national or pooled database. Visibility does not expand unless the agency takes deliberate action.

Can other agencies access the data?

Sharing is off by default and requires the owning agency's deliberate approval. Another agency can access data only through a specific sharing relationship approved by the owning agency. That access is invite-only, visible and revocable. Sharing does not copy agency ALPR data into a shared repository, transfer ownership or connect agency ALPR data to a national pool.

Can an agency that receives shared data re-share it with other agencies?

No. Re-sharing is architecturally impossible, not just prohibited by policy. Sharing is federated: no data is copied when a sharing relationship is established. Because no copy exists, a recipient agency never acquires ownership of shared data and cannot share it further. Agencies can only share ALPR data they own.

Can the agency audit how shared data is accessed?

Yes. When sharing is enabled, access to shared ALPR data is logged and reviewable by the owning agency. The audit record includes recipient activity against shared data and changes to sharing relationships over time, so the agency can review who had access during a specific period.

Can the agency control what ALPR searches are permitted?

Yes. The agency configures which offense categories are authorized for ALPR searches. That configuration applies system-wide, covering the agency's own users and any agencies the data is shared with, so a single standard governs how ALPR can be used across the program. When performing an ALPR search, users must enter an offense category. If that category is not on the agency's authorized list, the search does not return ALPR data.

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OWNERSHIP, SHARING & HOTLISTS – CONTINUED

Can an agency use hotlists?

Yes. The agency controls which hotlists the system uses, including agency-owned lists, the National Crime Information Center (NCIC) and other official vehicle-status lists the agency is authorized to use. Any vehicle-status or owner-related details associated with a match come from the agency-authorized hotlist entry, not from a live registered-owner lookup.

Can the system look up who owns a vehicle?

No, not through a live registered-owner lookup. When a plate is read, the system compares it against agency-approved hotlists, which may include official vehicle-status lists the agency is legally authorized to use where configured. Any vehicle-status or owner-related details associated with a match come from the agency-authorized hotlist entry, not from a live registered-owner lookup.

Federal Access & Lawful Requests

Can federal agencies access the data?

There is no automatic, standing or built-in federal access to agency ALPR data through Axon. Because the agency owns and controls the data, a lawful request goes to the agency and its counsel to handle. If Axon receives such a request, Axon directs it to the agency as the data owner and discloses data only where legally required to do so.

What stops this from being used for immigration enforcement?

This is a local policy decision that the agency governs through its own policy and applicable law. The system provides no automatic, standing or built-in access to any federal agency, including immigration enforcement. If Axon receives a request for agency ALPR data, Axon directs it to the agency as the data owner and provides data only where legally required to do so. If a request goes directly to the agency, the agency decides how to respond under its own policy and applicable law.

Are ALPR records subject to public records requests?

Public records obligations depend on state and local law. The agency is responsible for reviewing and responding to public records requests under its policies and applicable law. ALPR reads, hits, audit records or related materials may require legal review and redaction before any external disclosure.

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Retention, Oversight & Misuse

How long is data kept?

ALPR detection data is retained according to the agency's configured retention policy and removed when the applicable retention period expires. Detections preserved as evidence follow the agency's evidence retention rules. The agency sets retention periods according to its policy and applicable law, and the system enforces configured retention settings.

Is governance enforced by design or just by policy?

Policy sets the agency's rules. System design and configuration controls help enforce those rules, and audit records help the agency review use against them. Agency ownership, explicit sharing, configured retention and logged activity are reflected in how the system works and in the records the agency can review.

What prevents misuse of the system?

Access is limited to authorized users, and every ALPR search and relevant system action is logged with user, action, time and, where configured, stated reason. The agency can assign an audit owner, review activity on a defined cadence and enforce policy through investigation, access restrictions and disciplinary action when needed.

What happens if a hotlist match turns out to be incorrect?

A hotlist match generates an alert, not a stop. Officers review every alert and make all enforcement decisions based on their own assessment and applicable law. The system's role ends at detection. What happens next is governed by the agency's policies, officer training and applicable legal standards. The agency remains responsible for establishing how officers respond to alerts and how those decisions are reviewed over time.

Can an agency show the community how the system is governed?

Yes. Axon offers a public transparency portal an agency can use to disclose its data retention policies and available aggregate ALPR program information. The agency decides whether to publish it and controls which available elements appear. It stays off until the agency turns it on, and the agency can deactivate it at any time. It publishes aggregate information only, no plate numbers, images, individual records or camera locations. When an agency has sharing enabled, the portal can also disclose the partner agencies with whom data is shared.

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RETENTION, OVERSIGHT & MISUSE – CONTINUED

How can the agency communicate program outcomes to the public over time?

The agency decides what to report, how often and through what channels. That may include aggregate metrics or approved examples such as recovered vehicles, investigative leads, missing person responses or AMBER and Silver Alert support, where available and appropriate. The Axon transparency portal gives agencies a tool to publish aggregate program information publicly. Agencies can also include outcome summaries in council presentations, annual reports or community updates. Agencies should not publish raw ALPR reads, plate numbers, images, exact camera locations, active investigation details, user-level audit logs or personal information.

AI & Scope

Does the system use AI to predict crime or flag people?

No. AI reads plate characters and basic vehicle attributes from images. It is not used to predict behavior, assign risk scores or identify individuals.

Is agency data used to train AI?

Axon's agreements with AI providers prohibit them from using agency data to train their models. Axon trains its own AI primarily on self-collected and synthetic data. An agency's ALPR data can also contribute to improving Axon's products, including AI, through the Axon Customer Experience Improvement Program (ACEIP). Participation is optional, and the agency can decline or withdraw at any time. Every approved ACEIP use case is published on Axon's ACEIP transparency portal, with the data used and the safeguards applied listed for each.

What stops this from expanding into something more invasive over time?

New capabilities do not become part of the agency's program unless the agency approves or configures them under its policy and contract.

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Vendor Access, Verification & Accuracy

Does Axon access agency data?

Axon has no standing access to agency ALPR data. Access occurs only when an agency initiates a specific support request. When that happens, access is temporary, limited to the stated purpose, logged and auditable by the agency.

Is the system independently verified?

Yes. Axon publishes current security and compliance documentation through trust.axon.com. Agencies should use that documentation to confirm which products, services and controls are in scope for each audit or certification. For governance detail, see the Axon Vehicle Intelligence Governance Guide.

What happens if the system gets it wrong?

Accuracy can vary with conditions such as lighting, camera angle and plate visibility. That is why a person reviews every alert before any action is taken. The agency has verification procedures to confirm information before an operational decision is made.

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Cameras, Livestreaming & Recording

Do these cameras livestream and record, and how is that governed?

Livestreaming is permission-based and configurable. It is active only when an authorized user pulls up a feed for real-time viewing during an active situation. An agency controls whether it is enabled.

Video is handled under its own access, storage and retention controls, which are separate from how ALPR detection data is governed. Where an agency enables and configures recording, video is retained under the agency's video retention settings, not its ALPR retention settings. Video access is logged and auditable by the agency.

Core boundaries are built into how the system works. The system does not place agency ALPR data into a national pool, does not share data automatically, does not use facial recognition, does not perform live registered-owner lookups and does not automate enforcement. Within those boundaries, each agency configures retention, access, sharing, transparency and livestreaming or recording settings under its policy and applicable law.

For governance detail, see the Axon Vehicle Intelligence Governance Guide. For current security and certification documentation, see trust.axon.com.

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